Appendix A · Research evidence

QuickVolunteer: a micro-volunteering web application. Research carried out from 9 to 29 October 2026 for the CPU4106 Group Project. Research lead: Khadija Idbihi, with Alexandra Nastase and Gioacchino Rendine.

SDG 11 Sustainable cities and communities (main) · **SDG 10** Reduced inequalities, target 10.2 · **SDG 17** Partnerships for the goals

A1 · Research design

Research question. How might QuickVolunteer help people request and offer small practical tasks in a way that feels manageable, clear and safe?

RQ1 Time. What time commitment makes volunteering realistic for busy people?

RQ2 Trust and safety. What makes people comfortable asking a stranger for help, or helping one?

RQ3 Format. In person, remote or hybrid? Does distance matter?

RQ4 Roles. Does one account for asking and offering help make sense?

MIXED-METHODS APPROACH [21]

Step	Method	Detail	When
1	Secondary research	NCVO and DCMS national surveys	Sprint 1
2	Questionnaire	Google Forms, 14 questions, 6 respondents	9-10 Oct
3	Competitor review	4 services, 7 dimensions	Sprint 1
4	Personas and journeys	4 personas, 4 journey maps	Sprint 1
5	Prototype testing	Figma prototype, 4 testers	By 15 Oct
6	Live-site testing	Same 4 testers	Sprint 3

Secondary research gave national context; the questionnaire tested whether it applied to potential users; the competitor review showed what already exists; testing showed what users need when they use the product.

A2 · Secondary research

NCVO TIME WELL SPENT 2023 [1]-[3]

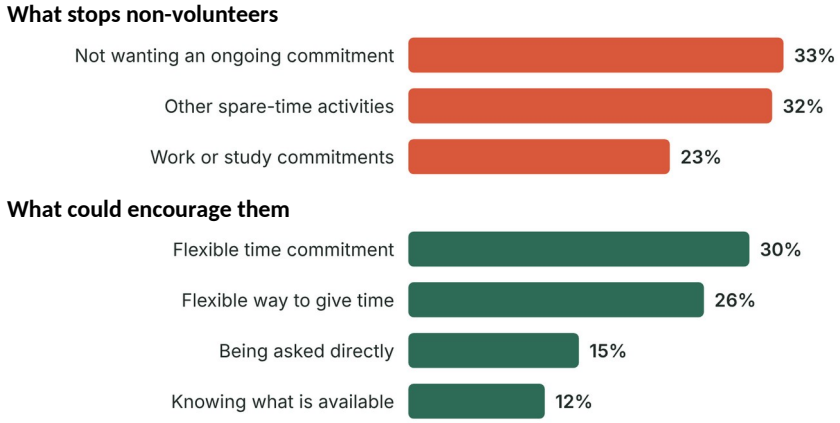


Figure A1. Barriers and enablers for non-volunteers (NCVO, 2023; 7,006 adults in Great Britain, YouGov, fieldwork Nov-Dec 2022). Each figure has its own base.

31%
of recent volunteers helped online or by phone

18%
volunteered only remotely

21%
chose local community groups, the most popular cause

92%
of recent formal volunteers were satisfied

Reading. People are willing; the obstacle is commitment. Flexible time and flexible ways to help are the two strongest enablers.

DCMS COMMUNITY LIFE SURVEY 2024/25 [4]

Formal volunteering at least once a month, England

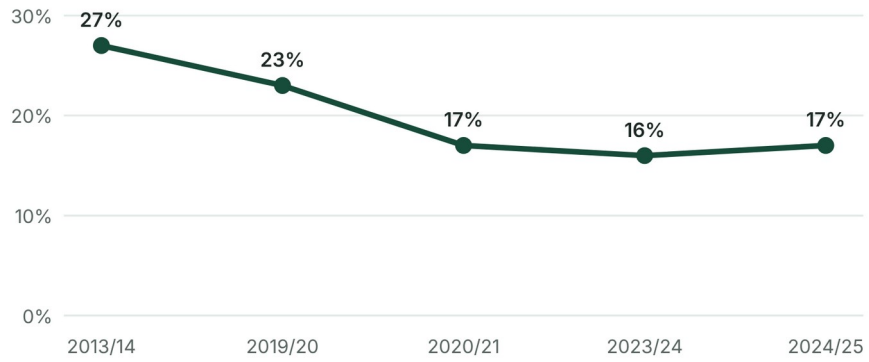


Figure A2. Regular formal volunteering fell from 27% to 17% and has not recovered (2024/25 not significantly different from 2023/24).

Monthly formal volunteering by age

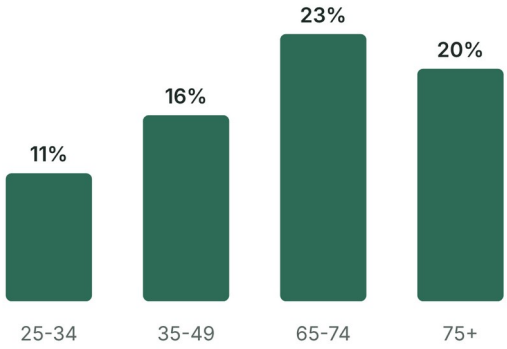


Figure A3. Working-age adults volunteer least. 51% of adults who do not volunteer regularly name work commitments.

HYPOTHESES TAKEN INTO PRIMARY RESEARCH

	Hypothesis	Evidence
H1	Short tasks with a clear time commitment will fit around work and study	NCVO 33%, 30%; DCMS 51%
H2	Remote as well as in-person options will widen who can help	NCVO 31% online or by phone
H3	Trust and safety will decide whether people ask strangers for help or offer it	Competitor review (A4)
H4	One account for asking and helping is simpler than two account types	User research board

Table A1. Hypotheses derived from secondary research. National data describes patterns; it does not prove what QuickVolunteer users need.

A3 · Questionnaire

Google Forms questionnaire, 14 questions, answered by 6 people on 9-10 October 2026. No names, emails or other personal data were collected [20].

6
responses

5 / 6
based in London

4 / 6
interested but have never volunteered

3 / 4
who needed help did not get it (2 did not ask, 1 could not find help)



Figure A4. What matters to respondents when using a platform that connects volunteers and people asking for help (n = 6, multiple answers allowed). The sample is small, so results guide design decisions and cannot be generalised.

Usefulness: 4.83 / 5. Five respondents rated a free local platform 5 and one rated it 4.

A finding not yet built. 4 of 6 wanted to contact a volunteer directly. Because contact between strangers raises safeguarding risks, the messaging back end was built in Sprint 3 and the messaging page is planned for the next version.

A4 · Competitor review

Four existing services were reviewed against seven dimensions using their public websites [9]-[12]. A feature not found in the reviewed pages is recorded as not confirmed, not as absent.

Doit Life
UK-wide
Micro-volunteering actions; one-off and ongoing roles; remote opportunities.

Simply Volunteer London
London
Search by keyword, activity, skills and location; local roles.

HandsOn London
London
Organised local activities with no long-term commitment; remote options.

Reach Volunteering
UK-wide
Skills-based and trustee matching for charities; managed closure announced.

Dimension	Doit Life	Simply Volunteer	HandsOn London	Reach	QuickVolunteer
Individuals can post a small help request	×	×	×	×	✓
One account to ask for help and to help	?	?	?	?	✓
Local and remote options	✓	?	✓	✓	✓
Matching by skills and distance	Search	Search	Sign-up	Skills search	✓
Safety and reporting documented publicly	?	?	?	?	✓
Public outcomes independently verified	?	?	?	?	**Not yet**

Table A2. Comparison matrix. ✓ confirmed · × organisation-led listings only · ? not confirmed in the reviewed public pages.

Today

- Requests are scattered across group chats, social media and notice boards
- Platforms are run by organisations, not neighbours
- Safety and reporting are rarely explained publicly

QuickVolunteer

- Peer-to-peer help between neighbours
- Tasks of 15 to 60 minutes, in person or remote
- One account to ask and to help; safety built in

Positioning to validate, not a proof of unmet need. Digital coordination of community support has worked at scale, e.g. the NHS volunteer programme [15] and Greater Manchester's support app [16].

A5 · Testing with users

Four people tested both the Figma prototype (Sprint 1) and the live website (Sprint 3): two team members, Khadija and Gioacchino, and two people from outside the team, Sohel and Chaymaa.

Finding (prototype)	Team decision	Improvement
The entry point needed to support people who both ask for and offer help	One shared login for both journeys	One login and one account (US-01; US-03 merged)
Organisations and donations were broader than the micro-volunteering scope	Remove them from Version 1	Prototype focused on individuals and short tasks
Some elements had insufficient contrast	Improve contrast	Text and interface contrast adjusted
Help seekers wanted to know who is coming	Show a summary before choosing	Member summary (US-22)

Table A3. Prototype review findings and improvements (Prototype Review and Improvements, Sprint 1).

Finding (live site)	Change made
3/4 testers were unsure whether “filled” meant that a task was finished.	The task status now reads “Volunteer accepted” or “Accepted · [name]” instead of “filled”.
2/4 testers wanted to see the volunteer’s verification status before applying.	The Verified badge is shown in the member summary before a volunteer offers to help.
2/4 testers had difficulty finding how to report a concern.	A “Report a concern about this task” link with a flag icon was added to the task page.

Table A4. Live-site testing findings and the changes made (Sprint 3).

A6 · From evidence to requirements

Evidence	Decision	User stories	MoSCoW
Time matters 5/6 · NCVO 33%	Every task lasts 15 to 60 minutes (enforced by the database)	US-04, US-05	Must
Distance matters 4/6 · NCVO 31% online	In person or remote; distance filter from a postcode	US-04, US-05	Must
Trust concerns 6/6 · verified accounts requested 6/6	Optional ID verification with a Verified badge and filter	US-11	Must
Report suspicious requests 5/6	Report a concern; admin review; delete a request	US-12, US-28	Must, Should
No contact details 6/6	Only the area name is shown; email and phone never shown	US-02, US-22	Must, Should
Prototype testing	One account to ask and to help	US-01	Must
Testers wanted to know who is coming	Member summary before choosing	US-22	Should
SDG 10.2 · persona Nadia	Accessibility tools on every page	US-19	Should
Contact a volunteer 4/6	Messaging back end built; page in the next version	US-17	Won't (this time)

Table A5. Traceability from research findings to user stories and MoSCoW priorities [18].

HOW THE SCOPE CHANGED

First research (Sprint 1)

- Organisations publish opportunities: Must
- Campaigns and donations
- Status: open, matched, in progress, completed, cancelled
- ID verification: Could

Version 1 (after the Sprint 1 review, 15 Oct)

- Individuals only; organisations Won't (this time)
- Donations need regulated payment providers: later
- Status: open, filled, completed, closed
- ID verification: Must (optional for members); 6/6 respondents asked for verified accounts. Verification uses an ID document.

A7 · Ethics and limitations

Ethics and privacy

- Persona photos are AI-generated and labelled
- Members type only a postcode; others see only the area; ID files deleted after the check
- No medical details in task descriptions (special category data [14]; NHS guidance [13])

Limitations

- Small, mostly London-based convenience sample (n = 6)
- The questionnaire was written before the scope change and still asked about organisations
- The external testers knew the team, which may make feedback more positive
- National surveys use different bases and areas (Great Britain vs England)
- Not solved in Version 1: safe contact after acceptance, and how shopping costs are repaid

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